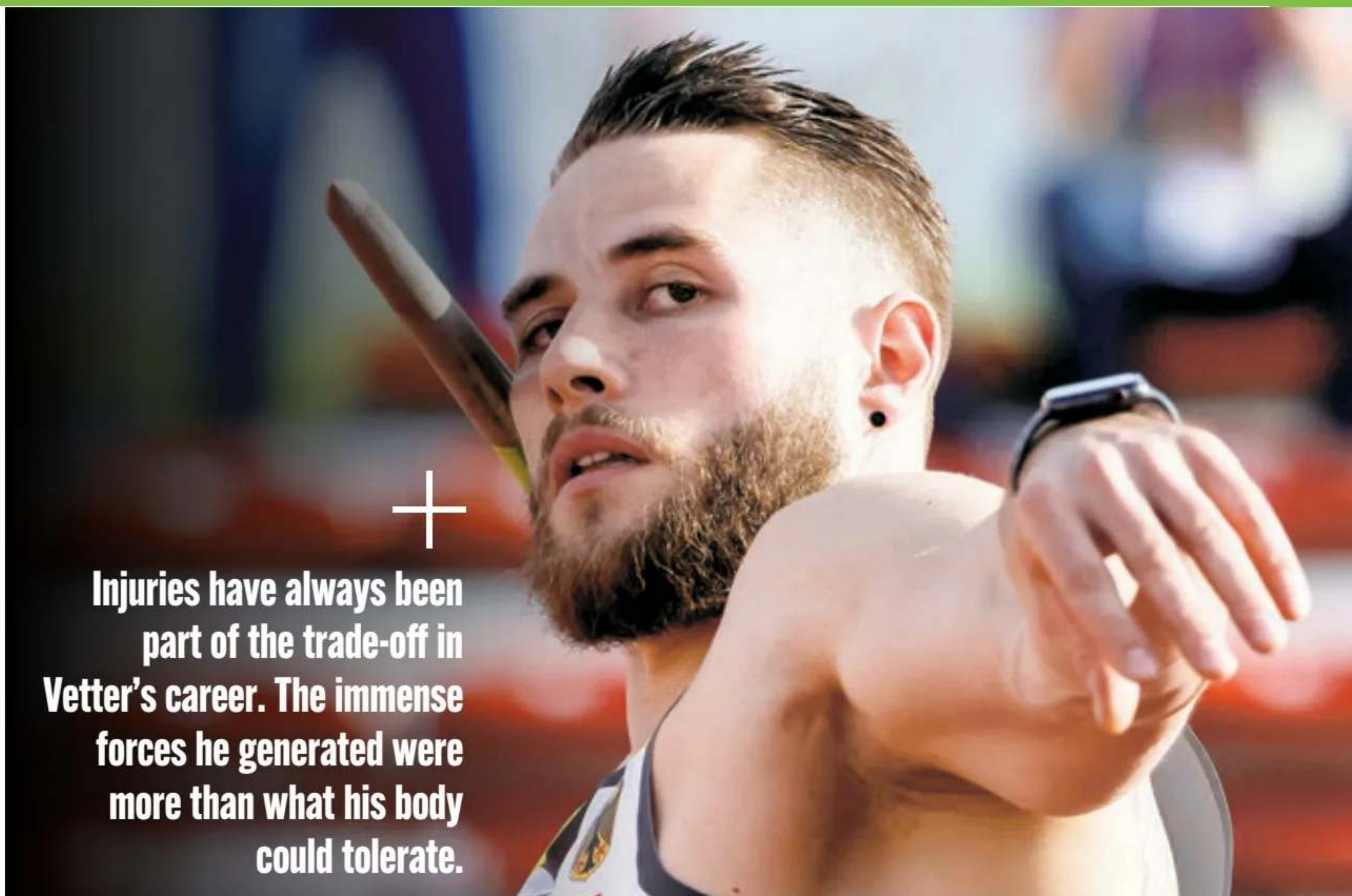




+ Injuries have always been part of the trade-off in Vetter's career. The immense forces he generated were more than what his body could tolerate.

especially so when he missed his second straight World Championships in a row last year — a competition that was won once again by Neeraj.

"It's not a great feeling when you see that others are competing but you aren't. People might say why I didn't just avoid looking at what others are doing but I couldn't really switch off. I mean, you can turn your social media off but you can also see the results on the internet or on the TV. There's a lot of media where you definitely see the results from the Worlds. I mean, I can't do anything about that," he tells *Sportstar*.

Injuries though have always been part of the trade-off in Vetter's career. The German, standing at 6 foot 2 inches and weighing 105 kg, is probably one of the most explosive throwers on the circuit but the immense forces he generates are often more than his body can tolerate.

A bronze at the Doha World championships was followed by a

foot surgery post-cartilage damage. He has been suffering from persistent shoulder pain since the winter of 2021. "Sometimes I cannot help it (injuries) because it comes with the power I put into the throws. I'm also 31 now so I'm starting to get old as a professional athlete and especially in a sport like the javelin. There are a lot of big forces that act on the body when you throw the javelin that far. And yeah, I mean, I try to push my own limit to the maximum all day. So sometimes s*#t happens and then you get injured. But it's part of the business," he shrugs.

Hardest comeback

Vetter's most recent comeback from injury has also been his hardest. It took nearly a year and a half to simply diagnose the problem. "The last few years have been pretty hard. The main issue was that the doctors couldn't find out what the problem was. That was the worst time of my career, where I knew I was having an

Far from his best: At the Tokyo Games, Vetter complained of not finding enough grip on the runways, slipped on his first attempt and only managed to throw 82.52m. GETTYIMAGES

injury but the doctors didn't know what the problem was," he says.

Although the injury couldn't be diagnosed, Vetter could certainly feel it, particularly at the point of the greatest tension when either throwing or lifting weights. "There was enormous pain," he says.

As his body tried to protect him, Vetter says he had to consciously will himself to throw instead of instinctively flinging it as he had done on previous occasions. Speaking to a German newspaper, he said that he couldn't even throw a stone into water intuitively. Instead, he had to concentrate on repeating the movements of the throw before he could manage such a simple task.

"It was only at the end of summer last year when we started to